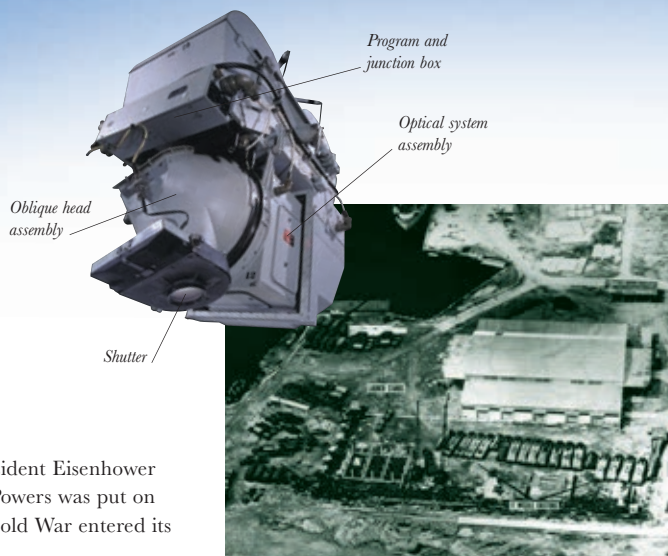




AERIAL PHOTOGRAPHY

The Lockheed U-2's effectiveness depended on the development of cameras capable of reconnaissance photography from over 70,000ft (22,000m). This camera (right) is a Hycon B used in U-2 reconnaissance over Cuba in late 1962. The picture far right shows missile erectors and launch stands in Cuba during the missile crisis.



summit conference with President Eisenhower and other Western leaders. Powers was put on trial for espionage and the Cold War entered its most unstable phase.

Soviet basing of missiles in Cuba precipitated the crisis that brought the world to the brink of nuclear war in 1962. Overflying Cuba, which had become an outpost of communism, U-2s from Edwards Air Force Base photographed preparations to install Soviet medium-range ballistic missiles on the island. As the American government demanded a withdrawal of Soviet missiles, the nuclear bomber force went on red alert, with 70 B-52s airborne at all times on 24-hour shifts. Before the crisis ended, another U-2 was shot down by a Soviet SAM, this time over Cuba. Its pilot was the only casualty in a crisis that could have resulted in the deaths of millions.

Changing arsenals

The Cuban Missile Crisis took place at a moment when major shifts were taking place in the nuclear arsenal. Intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBMs) and submarine-launched missiles were beginning to supersede bombers as the main delivery systems for nuclear devices, although aircraft remained an important part of the panoply of strategic nuclear weaponry. The need to penetrate enemy defenses at low level meant that fighter-bombers were increasingly prominent in a diversified strategic strike force alongside heavy bombers, and that the high-altitude interceptor was out of date.

SPY IN THE SKY

Built to meet a joint CIA/USAF requirement, the top-secret Lockheed U-2 spyplane was a unique source of intelligence for the United States until the advent of reconnaissance satellites in the 1960s.

Satellites took over much of the burden of military reconnaissance, although the SR-71 Blackbird coming into service in 1966 proved that with sufficient speed and altitude it was possible for an aircraft to defy any missile defense system.

Although the Cuban Missile Crisis ushered in a period of relative détente in the Cold War, the nuclear arms race never stopped. From the mid-1960s, however, attention was distracted from the possibility of a nuclear war by the reality of conventional warfare. While airmen continued to train and stand on alert for the nuclear "big show" that never materialized, hot war flared in the Middle East and Southeast Asia.

SPYPLANE PILOT

Gary Powers was tried for espionage in the Soviet Union after being shot down in 1960. He was later "swapped" for a Soviet spy.

